

SHADE-LOVING PLANTS

Cool woodland floors and other shady areas make perfect homes for a wide range of large-leaved architectural plants. Unlike sun-lovers, these shade-dwellers must mop up as much available light as possible and, as a consequence, their foliage is generally large and thin. The soil beneath trees may also be quite dry, so some plants also sport shiny leaves with a waxy outer surface to help conserve moisture. Pastel colors stand out in the gloom, which is why many shade-loving plants bear pale flowers that will catch the attention of pollinating insects. Other plants bloom in winter, making the most of the increased light levels that are available when any neighboring deciduous trees are not in leaf.

There are many degrees of shade, from deep shade, such as that experienced at the back of north-facing borders, to

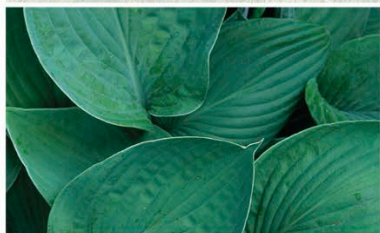
dappled and partial shade, where the sun may shine for a few hours of the day. Plant choices are restricted in areas of deep shade and the best option is to introduce as much light as possible. Prune overhead trees and shrubs, and consider removing any structures that cause shade. Moist shade suits more plants than dry shade, so try increasing soil moisture by improving it with organic matter, such as compost or shredded leaves, or create a plastic-lined bog garden.

To transform your gloomy garden into a cool calm oasis, combine foliage with different textures, sizes, and shapes, and include a range of seasonal flowers to highlight your scheme. As you will see, shade is a bonus, never a problem.

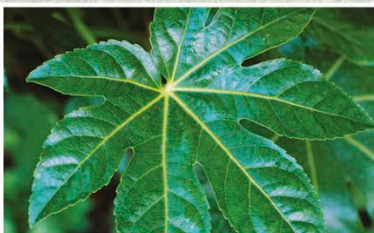
Cooling off in the shade Large dramatic leaves and delicate flowers can scorch under hot sun.



KEY CHARACTERISTICS OF SHADE-LOVING PLANTS



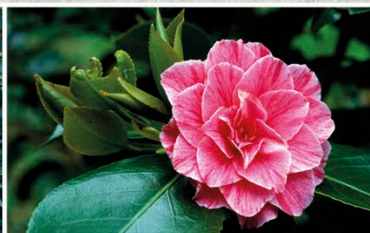
Large thin leaves Plants adapted to shade have large leaves that can absorb low light.



Glossy foliage Shiny foliage reflects the available light onto adjacent leaves and adds sparkle.



Winter flowers Some plants flower only in winter when deciduous trees are bare.



Evergreen foliage Permanent leaf cover enables many shade-lovers to grow all year.